



**V INTERNATIONAL
RURAL WOMEN
CONFERENCE**
African Voices Sowing the Future
Leadership, resilience and
sustainability from rural areas

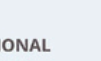
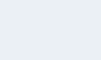
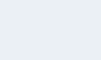
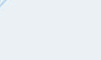


V International Rural Women Conference, Lagos 2026 Report

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The beginning of the Conference

The conference opened with a **powerful artistic expression** led by **Quinndy Akeju**, an artist and activist and co-founder of Africolectiva.

Her cultural dance performance set a reflective and symbolic tone for the gathering, highlighting the role of art as a medium for storytelling, identity, and social change.

It served as a reminder that culture and creativity are deeply intertwined with the lived experiences and voices of African women.

More about [Quinndy Akeju](#).



Opening Remarks



In the opening remarks, **Edna Dafe** from **Women's Board** highlighted some of the key challenges faced by rural women, including low self-esteem, limited access to financial resources, and exclusion from decision-making processes within their communities.

These structural barriers continue to limit women's full participation in social and economic life.

More about [Women's Board, Nigeria](#).



Building on this, **Susana** from **Zabalketa** offered a powerful reflection on the inherent dignity and strength of women. She described women as "seeds that feed the planet," emphasising their role in sustaining families, communities, and economies.

Despite differences in language and geography, she noted that women's work speaks a universal language of perseverance, creativity, and resilience. Importantly, she reinforced the idea that women are not passive recipients of support, but active agents of change with the ability to express their ideas, create, and lead.

More about [Zabalteka](#).

More about [Redmujeres](#).

Day 1

Participation and Public Representation of Rural Women

The first panel, titled “*Participation and Public Representation of Rural Women*,” explored the gap between the presence of women in public spaces and their actual influence in decision-making processes.

A central question emerged: **Is public representation truly meaningful, or is it merely symbolic?**

Panelists emphasised that rural women are fundamental to the functioning of society, particularly in food production and community sustainability.

Without them, there is no food security and no continuity of life. However, when women are included only superficially, without real decision-making power, societal progress remains stagnant.



Structural Barriers to Participation

The discussion highlighted several systemic barriers that continue to limit women’s participation:

- Patriarchal governance structures
- Cultural and religious norms that restrict women’s roles
- Early marriages limiting access to education for girls
- Economic dependency within households

These factors not only reduce women’s visibility in leadership but also limit their ability to act independently and contribute meaningfully to development initiatives.

A representative from [Kianda Foundation](#) noted that many policies promoting women’s inclusion are often implemented superficially, to “tick a box”, rather than being rooted in genuine representation. As a result, women may occupy positions without having real influence or support.

Additionally, issues such as a lack of support from spouses, particularly when women initiate projects or generate income, further complicate their ability to lead. Financial independence can sometimes be perceived as a threat within traditional household dynamics.

Reframing Women as Agents of Change

Despite these challenges, a strong and consistent message throughout the panel was that women are not victims; they are agents of change.

Panelists highlighted the importance of:

- Supporting women-led income-generating initiatives
- Recognising the value of informal and community-based work
- Building trust through small, consistent actions
- Encouraging peer learning, where trained women mentor others

Although women's initiatives may not always generate income at the same level as traditionally male-dominated sectors, they are often more sustainable and community-oriented. Over time, these efforts can gain recognition, respect, and broader support — including from government structures.

Representation, Identity, and Voice

Quinnndy Akeju brought a critical perspective on representation by reflecting on the concept of African liberation. She noted that historical narratives of liberation often centre male figures such as Nelson Mandela and Fela Kuti, while **the contributions of women remain underrepresented**.

She emphasised the importance of **reclaiming women's stories and understanding history, stating that a people without knowledge of their past are like "a tree without roots."** Rather than striving to emulate male models of leadership, she encouraged women to define their own paths to growth and flourishing.

She further highlighted the importance of raising future generations differently, particularly in teaching young boys to respect women, and challenged the notion that women should remain silent. Instead, she advocated for women to speak with clarity, confidence, and purpose, especially when it matters most.

Building Meaningful Participation

Ines Gonzalez Barreda from Etsoseng Foundation contributed a perspective focused on measuring meaningful participation.

She emphasised that true participation goes beyond physical presence — it must include **influence, voice, and sustainability of impact**.

A key strategy highlighted was the importance of starting with girls. By equipping young women early with confidence, leadership skills, and a sense of security, they are better prepared to participate meaningfully in the future.

She also noted that:

- Activities themselves are not the end goal, but part of a longer developmental journey
- Practical skills such as budgeting, leadership, and community engagement are essential
- Mental health support and accompaniment are critical for holistic development

Importantly, she stressed that academic intelligence alone is not sufficient. Young women need **soft skills, guidance, and personal development** to navigate complex social and professional environments.

Toward Long-Term Transformation

The panel concluded with a broader reflection on the need for both **personal and structural transformation**.

Key themes included:

- Changing mindsets and cultural perceptions of women
- Developing strong personal identity and dignity
- Promoting accountability in leadership
- Encouraging transparency and ethical responsibility

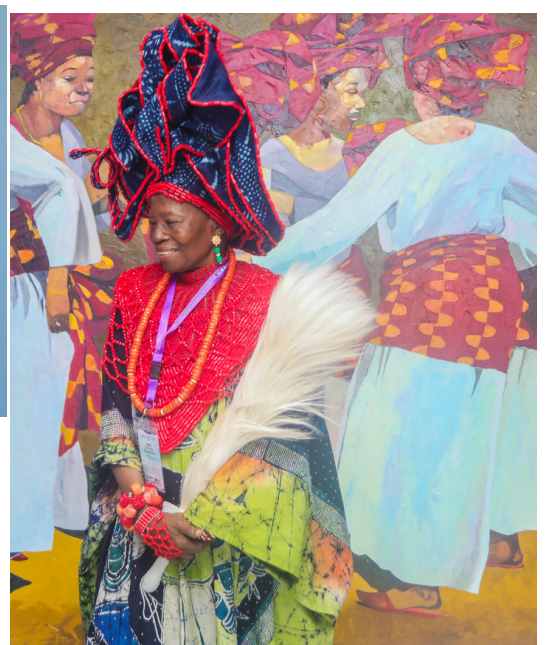
There was also a call to move toward **sustainable models beyond dependency on funding**, incorporating elements such as sports, arts, mental health, and community-based activities. These approaches support more holistic and enduring forms of empowerment.

Art Exhibition:

“Art as a Rural Voice”

The day concluded with an art exhibition and guided tour titled “Art as a Rural Voice,” led by **Nike Davies-Okundaye** at the **Nike Art Gallery**.

This experience reinforced the role of art as a powerful medium for expressing **rural realities, preserving cultural identity, and amplifying women’s voices**. Through visual storytelling, the exhibition highlighted the intersection of creativity, heritage, and social commentary, offering a deeper understanding of the lived experiences of women in rural communities.



Day 2

Keynote Address: Access to Financing and International Networks

Day 2 of the conference began with a keynote address on “*Access to Financing and International Networks*,” delivered by Ezinne Ukagwu from the Iroto Rural Development Center.

Ezinne Nigerian economist and director of the Iroto Rural Development Centre, a women's capacity building centre in Ogún, Nigeria.



The keynote focused on one of the most critical challenges facing women-led initiatives: **access to sustainable and well-managed financial resources**. While funding is often viewed as the primary barrier, the discussion emphasised that effective financing begins with clarity of purpose and strong internal systems.

Clarity of Identity and Purpose

A central message of the keynote was the importance of self-awareness in leadership. Women and organisations were encouraged to begin by asking:

“Who am I, and what am I doing?”

This question, though simple, was presented as foundational. Having a clear understanding of one's mission, vision, and intended impact allows organisations to communicate effectively with funders and build trust. Without this clarity, access to funding becomes inconsistent and unsustainable.

Financial Literacy and Accountability

The keynote highlighted the importance of financial literacy and transparency as key components of sustainability. Access to funding is not only about securing resources, but also about managing them responsibly.

Key practices discussed included:

- Maintaining accurate bookkeeping systems
- Tracking expenses, profits, and losses
- Using data and statistics to demonstrate impact (e.g., number of beneficiaries)
- Providing regular and structured feedback to funders

These practices were presented as essential for building credibility and ensuring long-term partnerships.

Communication and Trust in Partnerships

Another important theme was the role of **clear and continuous communication** between organisations and their funding partners.

Effective partnerships require:

- Open and honest reporting
- Regular updates on progress and challenges
- Transparency in how funds are used

This “fluid communication” strengthens relationships and allows both parties to align their expectations and goals. Trust, once established, becomes a key driver of continued support and collaboration.

Sustainability and Continuity

The keynote also stressed that successful initiatives must be designed with **long-term sustainability in mind**.

Rather than focusing only on short-term funding cycles, organisations were encouraged to:

- Build systems that ensure continuity beyond initial funding
- Develop group-based or community-driven initiatives
- Strengthen internal capacity to maintain and grow projects over time

Sustainability was framed as a mark of strong leadership, the ability to ensure that impact continues even when external support changes.

The Role of International Networks

Finally, the importance of international networks was highlighted as a means of expanding opportunities for collaboration, learning, and funding.

By connecting with organisations across different regions, women-led initiatives can:

- Share knowledge and best practices
- Access new funding opportunities
- Strengthen their visibility and influence on a global scale

These networks not only provide resources but also create a sense of solidarity among women working toward similar goals across different contexts.

Key Takeaway

The keynote reinforced that **access to financing is not only about resources, but about readiness**.

Organisations that are clear in their mission, transparent in their processes, and consistent in their communication are better positioned to access and sustain funding.

Ultimately, building strong financial foundations enables women-led initiatives to move from short-term projects to **long-term, sustainable impact** within their communities.

Panel Discussion: Climate Change, Sustainability and Female Resilience

Day 2 of the conference also featured a panel discussion titled “*Climate Change, Sustainability and Female Resilience*,” which brought together practitioners and educators working at the intersection of environmental sustainability, skills development, and women’s empowerment.

The panel explored how climate change disproportionately affects women, particularly young women, and how programmes, institutions, and partnerships can respond in ways that build long-term resilience.

Key Themes and Questions Explored

The discussion focused on several critical areas, including:

- How sustainability and climate awareness can be integrated into training programmes for women and youth
- The role of vocational and skills-based education in addressing both economic and climate vulnerability
- Practical strategies to ensure sustainability initiatives benefit women at the grassroots level
- The importance of mentorship in developing not only employability, but also environmental responsibility and leadership

From an institutional perspective, Josephine Kayere Njuguna highlighted the role of Technical and Vocational Education and Training (TVET) in embedding sustainability into curricula. Discussions emphasised the need for education systems, particularly in sectors such as hospitality, to prepare young women for climate-related disruptions, while also fostering socially responsible and environmentally conscious professionals.

The panel also examined the need for systemic shifts within education systems to ensure that women are not only technically competent but also equipped with the mindset and awareness required to engage with sustainability challenges.

Barriers to Women’s Participation in Climate Action

A key part of the discussion focused on the challenges young women face in engaging with climate action.

One of the main barriers identified was a **lack of awareness about how directly environmental issues affect daily life**. In many communities, young women are often focused on immediate priorities such as completing school, securing employment, and supporting their families. In this context, environmental action can feel distant or secondary.

However, the panel emphasised that **climate change is already deeply connected to these basic needs**.

For example, limited green space and high population density contribute to the creation of **urban heat islands**, where temperatures are significantly higher due to concrete infrastructure and lack of vegetation. This impacts health, increases vulnerability to extreme weather, and limits opportunities for small-scale food production. Additionally, flooding can damage informal housing and disrupt livelihoods.

Another challenge discussed was that many young women do not see themselves as active **participants in climate solutions**, often perceiving environmental work as the domain of experts, governments, or large organisations.

Making Climate Action Participatory

The panel emphasised that addressing these barriers requires making climate action more **accessible, relevant, and participatory**.

Programmes that actively involve young women in practical initiatives, such as community gardens or urban forests, allow them to experience their role as contributors rather than passive beneficiaries. Through participation, they begin to understand the direct link between environmental sustainability and their own well-being.

When environmental initiatives are connected to community needs and everyday realities, they become more meaningful and sustainable.

Building a Model for Female Climate Resilience

Looking ahead, the panel highlighted the importance of developing community-based models that combine climate adaptation and climate mitigation.

Adaptation refers to how communities respond to the impacts of climate change that are already being experienced – such as extreme heat, flooding, and food insecurity. In many African contexts, women are already at the forefront of these responses through their roles in households and communities.

Mitigation, on the other hand, focuses on long-term environmental solutions, including restoring ecosystems and reducing future climate risks.

A promising approach lies in **integrating both adaptation and mitigation within community initiatives**.

An example discussed was the Ithuba Unity Forest, developed through Etsoseng Foundation in partnership with SUGi Project. Such projects contribute to mitigation by restoring biodiversity and creating green spaces that reduce urban heat. At the same time, they support adaptation by improving local environmental conditions, enabling small-scale food production, and creating spaces for learning and community engagement.

What makes these models particularly effective is the **active involvement of women and girls** – not only as beneficiaries, but as planners, participants, and stewards of these initiatives.

From Dialogue to Action

The panel concluded with a broader strategic discussion on how to move from dialogue to measurable impact.

Key considerations included:

- Identifying indicators that measure not only environmental outcomes, but also women's participation, leadership, and personal development
- Exploring scalable initiatives – particularly community-based education and leadership models – that can be replicated across different African contexts
- Defining female resilience in the climate era as the ability of women to not only adapt to environmental challenges, but also to lead solutions that benefit their communities
- Addressing immediate community needs
- Building long-term environmental solutions
- Empowering women with the knowledge, skills, and confidence to lead

Panel Discussion: Power, Inequalities and Structural Violence – Leading from Community Resilience

Another key session during the conference focused on “Power, Inequalities and Structural Violence: Leading from Community Resilience.” The panel, moderated by Chidera Anele, brought together diverse voices working at the intersection of gender, community development, and social justice.

Panelists included Pauline Irungu, Gbemisola Titilope Akosa, Ebere Oyema, and Refilwe Mokoena from Etsoseng Foundation.

Understanding Structural Barriers

The panel explored how **power dynamics, systemic inequalities, and structural violence** continue to shape the lived realities of women, particularly at the grassroots level.

Structural violence was discussed not only in its visible forms, such as gender-based violence, but also in more subtle, systemic ways, including:

- Limited access to education and economic opportunities
- Social norms that restrict women’s autonomy
- Unequal power relations within households and communities
- Institutional barriers that exclude women from decision-making



These interconnected challenges create environments where women’s potential is constrained, despite their central role in sustaining families and communities.

Community Resilience as a Form of Leadership

A key theme that emerged from the discussion was the idea that **resilience itself is a form of leadership**.

Across different contexts, women are already demonstrating resilience through:

- Supporting their families and communities in the face of economic hardship
- Creating informal support systems and networks
- Initiating community-based solutions to everyday challenges

However, the panel emphasised that while resilience is often celebrated, it must also be **supported and strengthened**, rather than taken for granted.

There was a call to shift from expecting women to simply endure challenges, to **creating environments where they can lead, influence, and transform systems**.

Reclaiming Power at the Community Level

Panelists highlighted the importance of **reclaiming power within communities** by strengthening women's agency and voice.

This includes:

- Creating safe spaces for women to express themselves
- Building confidence and leadership skills
- Encouraging participation in community decision-making processes
- Supporting women-led initiatives and organisations

The discussion reinforced that meaningful change often begins at the local level, where women are already deeply engaged in community life.

The Role of Organisations and Programmes

From a programme perspective, the panel emphasised the need for interventions that go beyond addressing immediate needs, and instead focus on **long-term transformation**.

This includes:

- Investing in personal development and mindset change
- Addressing both individual and structural barriers simultaneously
- Supporting collaboration between organisations working in different sectors
- Ensuring that programmes are inclusive, context-specific, and sustainable

The contribution from Refilwe Mokoena highlighted the importance of working closely with young women at the community level, creating spaces where they can build confidence, develop skills, and begin to see themselves as leaders within their own environments.

Key Takeaway

The panel underscored that **addressing inequality requires both structural change and personal empowerment**.

While policies and systems play a critical role, lasting impact depends on whether women are able to:

- Recognise their own agency
- Build supportive networks
- Actively participate in shaping their communities

Ultimately, community resilience is not only about coping with challenges, but about transforming power structures in ways that enable women to lead and thrive.



Day 3

Working Groups: “Action Plan to 2030: Leadership, Sustainability and Cooperation”



The conference also featured two dynamic working group sessions titled “*Action Plan to 2030: Leadership, Sustainability and Cooperation*” and “*Solidarity Economic Networks: Strategies for the Autonomy of Rural Women*.” These sessions created a collaborative space for participants to move from dialogue to practical solutions.

Key conclusions emphasised the importance of **capacity-building and structured support systems**.

Participants highlighted the need to actively assist rural women in enrolling in **adult education programmes** by securing local learning spaces, identifying teachers, and supporting the enrolment process.

A strong focus was placed on conducting **needs assessments** to ensure interventions are relevant, alongside providing training in **entrepreneurship, marketing, branding, legal compliance, and documentation**. Additional priority areas included **climate education, safeguarding, political participation, women’s rights, and policy advocacy** to empower women to influence decisions affecting their lives.

On the economic front, the working groups underscored the **value of collective financial models** to strengthen autonomy. Proposed strategies included **savings groups with regular contributions**, as well as accessing **collective grants and loans** through partnerships with investors, banks, and NGOs.

Participants also stressed the importance of **supporting rural women in proposal writing** and ensuring that financial mechanisms, especially micro-finance initiatives, are designed with **direct input from rural women to reflect their realities and needs**.

Mentorship from established businesswomen and **apprenticeship** opportunities, such as certifications in first aid and community-based services, were also identified as key pathways to sustainable economic empowerment.



LAGOS DECLARATION 2026

The declaration was adopted by rural women leaders from Africa and the Global South during the V International Rural Women Conference in Lagos, Nigeria. It recognizes the critical role of rural women in food security, sustainability, and community development, and sets out key commitments to strengthen their impact.

Core Focus Areas & Commitments

1. Leadership & Governance

- Promote the inclusion of rural women and youth in decision-making, ensure ethical leadership, and support generational succession through training and representation.

2. Economic Autonomy & Family Farming

- Strengthen access to land, water, and finance; promote entrepreneurship and fair markets; and advocate for public investment that supports rural women's economic contributions.

3. Climate Justice & Environmental Protection

- Recognise women as key environmental stewards, promote sustainable and circular economies, and push for climate justice to be central in policies.

4. Right to a Life Free from Violence

- Commit to eliminating all forms of violence (political, economic, domestic), and create support systems and prevention mechanisms.

5. Advocacy & Monitoring

- Establish systems (like observatories) to track progress, strengthen partnerships, and ensure measurable outcomes by 2030.

6. Cultural Identity & Heritage

- Protect and promote rural women's cultural expressions as both heritage and economic resources, and use art as a tool for advocacy.



Etsoseng's Participation in the Conference

Although the conference was primarily focused on rural women, the participation of Etsoseng Foundation was both appropriate and valuable. The Foundation's work with township women speaks to a closely related set of socio-economic realities that intersect with those experienced in rural contexts. Despite geographical differences, both rural and township communities face persistent structural challenges, including limited access to quality education, financial services, formal employment opportunities, and adequate infrastructure. Women in these environments are often engaged in informal economic activities while simultaneously bearing significant caregiving responsibilities, which further constrains their economic and social mobility.

Etsoseng Foundation's programmatic focus on skills development, entrepreneurship, and community-based support aligns directly with the conference's thematic priorities of leadership, sustainability, and economic autonomy. Its experience in implementing grassroots, needs-driven initiatives provides practical insights into effective models of empowerment that are transferable across contexts. In particular, its emphasis on participatory approaches, where women are actively involved in identifying challenges and co-creating solutions, resonates with the conference's commitment to locally grounded and responsive interventions.

Moreover, the inclusion of township-focused perspectives contributed to a more comprehensive understanding of the continuum between rural, peri-urban, and urban informal settings. These contexts are often interconnected through patterns of migration, economic exchange, and social networks, particularly in the Global South. As such, development strategies aimed at empowering women must take into account these linkages to ensure coherence and sustainability. Lessons drawn from township-based initiatives, including collective savings mechanisms, mentorship programmes, and micro-enterprise development, offer valuable points of reference for rural development efforts.

In this regard, the participation of Etsoseng Foundation reinforced the importance of cross-context collaboration and knowledge exchange. It highlighted the need to move beyond rigid geographic categorizations and instead adopt inclusive approaches that recognize the shared challenges and opportunities facing women across different but interconnected environments. This contribution strengthened the overall discourse of the conference and supported its objective of advancing integrated, women-led development pathways towards 2030.

[Etsoseng Foundation, South Africa.](#)

The Delegation

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